

CLASS MATERIAL

WEEK 3

CEL2103 WRITING ACADEMIC TEXTS
SEMESTER 2, 2024-2025

Developing Introductory Paragraph in Comparison and Contrast Essay

- Components of an introductory paragraph of a compare and contrast essay
 - Background Information

Components of an Introductory Paragraph

The introductory paragraph, or opening paragraph, is the first paragraph of your essay. It introduces the main idea of your essay and tells why your topic is important.

Activity 1

Write the **two** components in an introductory paragraph of a compare and contrast essay in the space provided.

- a. _____
- b. _____

Activity 2

Match the components of an introductory paragraph in **Activity 1** to the definitions below.

No	Definition	Component
1	Presents your subjects and your points of comparison that you will include in your essay. It should also be clear, and it is the last sentence of the introduction.	
2	Writes about the specific subjects of your essay. What is your essay about? This part helps to establish the subjects' context.	

Activity 3

Identify the two components of an introductory paragraph in the texts below by writing the sentence number for each component.

Introductory paragraph 1

¹Before the advent of computers and modern technology, people were communicating over long distances by using traditional means such as letters and the telephone. ²In the past, people wrote letters to communicate with friends and family because it was the only way to communicate long distance. ³Nowadays, a variety of communication tools can complete this task, ranging from email to instant messaging and video calls. ⁴While the present and past means of communication are similar in their purpose, they use different technology.

Adapted from: Smith, S. (2020, March 3). *Compare & Contrast Essay*.
https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/research_and_citation/apa_style/apa_formatting_and_style_guide/reference_list_electronic_sources.html

Background information:

Thesis statement:

Background Information

Activity 4

A good background information consists of a few elements. Based on the background information identified in Activity 3, answer the questions that follow.

Introductory paragraph 1

¹Before the advent of computers and modern technology, people were communicating over long distances by using traditional means such as letters and the telephone. ²In the past, people wrote letters to communicate with friends and family because it was the only way to communicate long distance. ³Nowadays, a variety of communication tools can complete this task, ranging from email to instant messaging and video calls. ⁴While the present and past means of communication are similar in their purpose, they use different technology.

Adapted from: Smith, S. (2020, March 3). *Compare & Contrast Essay*.
https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/research_and_citation/apa_style/apa_formatting_and_style_guide/reference_list_electronic_sources.html

1. Which sentence introduces the topic of the essay?

Sentence Number: _____

2. What are the subjects stated in the introductory paragraph?

3. Which sentence provides the general statement of the first subject?

Sentence Number: _____

4. Which sentence provides the general statement of the second subject?

Sentence Number: _____

Activity 5

Identify the three elements in a background information of an introductory paragraph by writing the sentence number for each element.

Topic: Similarity and difference between Facebook and Twitter

¹Since social media's origin over a decade ago, several sites have enjoyed time in the spotlight. ²Indeed, individuals of all ages and lifestyles often manage several social media accounts at the same time, ranging from the big names to more specific platforms such as Facebook and Twitter. ³The most favoured social media is Facebook, and it is used by many tweens and grandparents alike. ⁴Most individuals have one or more of these accounts and may even use them in integrated ways. ⁵Twitter, on the other hand, is not far behind, as it is also used by many. ⁶Twitter has a feature that allows users to post their tweets to other platforms, thus updating two sites at once. ⁷Facebook and Twitter have similar function but differ in the way users employ them.

Adapted from: Williams, S. (2014, May 6). *Social Media Giants*. <https://owl.excelsior.edu/wp-content/uploads/sites/2/2018/05/CompareContrastEssaySeeltInPractice.pdf>

Introduction of the topic of the essay : Sentence _____

General statement of the first subject : Sentence _____

General statement of the second subject : Sentence _____

Topic: A comparison of cultural practices between United Kingdom and China

¹Different countries across the world have diverse cultural practices, and this has an effect on work relationships and development. ²Geert Hofstede, a psychologist, came up with a structured way of comparing cultural dimensions of different countries such as United Kingdom and China. This theory explains the impacts of a community's culture on the values of the community members, and the way these values relate to their behaviours. ³For example, in China, their attitudes to time are different as the Chinese prefer slower negotiations. ⁴Meanwhile, in United Kingdom, their people believe that time is money and are in a hurry to conclude a deal. ⁵While United Kingdom and China share cultural similarities, these two countries also have different cultural practices based on Hofstede's Six Dimensions of Culture.

Adapted from: *Comparison Between the United Kingdom and China*. (2017, November). <https://samples.essaypro.com/Compare-and-Contrast-Essay/Uk-China-Comparison.pdf>

Introduction of the topic of the essay : Sentence _____
General statement of the first subject : Sentence _____
General statement of the second subject : Sentence _____

Activity 6

One of the elements in background information for each introductory paragraph below is missing. Identify the missing element and complete the introductory paragraph by writing the relevant sentence for the missing element.

Introductory Paragraph 1

Printed books are books in their physical form, consisting of pages or sheets of paper glued together inside the cover. However, with the world's current pandemic situation, all learning has been shifted to online platforms. Electronic books have now become ubiquitous and a part of life for the students. An electronic Book is a non-editable book that can be read on any electronic device with a configurable viewing display. Although books and electronic books provide an excellent and effective way of reading, they differ in accessibility.

Adapted from: *eBooks vs Books Essay*. (n.d.). <https://swiflearn.com/study-material/essay/ebooks-vs-books-essay/>

Missing element: _____

Answer: _____

Introductory Paragraph 2

It would almost seem abnormal for a person to not own a cell phone nowadays, but for some choosing which phone is right for them is rather difficult. With so many options to choose from, one may not know where to even begin in choosing a cell phone. Apple and Android are the two biggest companies currently on the market, with a lot of different models. Android, which is Linux-based and partly open source, is more PC-like which its interface and basic features are generally more customisable from top to bottom. Apple and Android are similar when it comes to cost; however, they have different features.

Adapted from: Bramer, D. (n.d.). *iPhone vs Android*.
<https://www.coursehero.com/file/19809364/Compare-and-Contrast-Essay-Don-Bramer/>

Missing element: _____

Answer: _____

Introductory Paragraph 3

Studying is a never-ending learning process that has always been a part in people's life to continue the path of success, be it studying locally or abroad. Recently, studying abroad has become a trend among the students. This is because it paves the way for new avenues as far as job openings are concerned. In today's global economy, employers often look for employees who have some international experience, as this provides a whole new level of global and cultural understanding. Although studying locally and abroad are similar in its benefits, they provide different opportunities.

Adapted from: *A Compare and Contrast Essay About Education*. (n.d.)

<https://www.studocu.com/my/document/universiti-pendidikan-sultan-idris/english-proficiency-4/english-proficiency-4/biu-2042-compare-and-contrast-essay-education/16123086>

Missing element: _____

Answer: _____

Activity 7

Below are the introductory paragraphs of compare and contrast essay. Identify whether the background information is acceptable or unacceptable and justify your reason.

Introductory paragraph 1

Marriage therapist and researcher John Gottman, Ph.D., has found that criticism, contempt, defensiveness and stonewalling are serious threats to a marriage. Marriage based on love is the pure feeling of attachment. Meanwhile, arranged marriage is like a blind date in hopes to find love. It could be love at first sight or love after a while. No matter whether it is love marriage or arranged marriage, some people think that eventually, the couple will be in love. Although arranged marriage and love marriage requires a lifelong commitment, they are different in terms of prior understanding towards each other.

Acceptable or unacceptable: _____

Reason: _____

Introductory paragraph 2

Over the last two decades, the demand from consumers for organic foods has increased tremendously. In fact, organic fruits and vegetables are more nutritious and wholesome than non-organic food. Organic foods have more vitamins, minerals, enzymes, and micronutrients than commercially grown foods because the soil is nourished with sustainable farming practices. On the other hand, inorganic foods are those that are grown using artificial chemicals. Inorganic food products are those that have been treated with artificial additives, such as preservatives, sweeteners, and flavouring. Organic and inorganic foods possess a number of significant differences. While organic and non-organic foods provide good nutrient contents, the cost between this type of foods is different.

Acceptable or unacceptable: _____

Reason: _____

Introductory Paragraph 3

School is one of the most important stages of educational system in children's lives where they are trained to absorb basic knowledge and prepare for their future. Often times, schools are divided into single-sex schools, where only boys or girls study, and co-ed schools, where boys and girls study together. These choices demand that parents choose between co-ed school and single-sex school and decide what would be better for their children. Although both co-ed schools and single-sex schools provide good learning experience to their students, they differ in terms of social skills.

Acceptable or unacceptable: _____

Reason: _____

Introductory Paragraph 4

The 21st century is the age of visual information. Most places are surrounded by all kinds of graphics, charts, commercials, logos, banners and other images. Be it a website, a billboard, a magazine, a comic book, a package—all the images are created by graphic designers: people whose profession is to draw. Unlike usual artists, graphic designers mostly work with customers, creating images based on their specific requirements; there is also one more difference: instead of a canvas, pencils, and dyes, graphic designers utilise special software programmes. Among the most popular and the most advanced programmes, Adobe Photoshop and Adobe Illustrator are the favourites of the majority of graphic designers. While Adobe Photoshop and Adobe Illustrator have many benefits in editing images, they differ in terms of the function.

Acceptable or unacceptable: _____

Reason: _____

Activity 8

Write an introduction of the topic for each background information in the introductory paragraph below.

Topic: Similarity and difference between two soft drinks: Pepsi and Coca-Cola

Pepsi is a company known for a highly diversified product portfolio, both within the beverage industry and in other industries such as the consumer-packaged goods industry. Meanwhile, Coca-Cola focuses on a diversified product portfolio within the beverage industry and has few products outside of that industry. While Pepsi and Coca-Cola have a similarity in marketing strategy, these drinks contain different nutritional content.

Topic: A Comparison of two cities in Japan: Tokyo and Kyoto

Tokyo is the political and economic capital of Japan, so it is much more bustling, modern and new. Kyoto, on the other hand, is the storehouse of Japan's traditional culture. To most people, Tokyo and Kyoto brings no difference as they have rich historical background, but these two places offer different outdoor experiences.

Topic: Similarity and difference of Boeing and Airbus

Boeing came into commercial aviation by launching its first aircraft, the B&W Seaplane, in 1916. The company went on to develop several small passenger and military aircraft in the two decades that followed, becoming a frontrunner in all-metal aircraft construction. The European company Airbus had a modest beginning with the launch of the A300B, which is based on the A300 wide-body jetliner. These companies have shared the sky for over 50 years and both brands have their adherents. Airbus and Boeing maybe almost similar when it comes to overall appearance, but they differ in the technical aspect.

Activity 9

Write the general statements for both subjects for each of the introductory paragraph below.

Topic: A comparison between the benefits of drinking coffee and drinking tea

A new study of 2,000 Americans examined the personality differences in people based on their morning beverage of choice: coffee or tea. _____

Topic: The similarity and difference of public universities and private universities

With 20 public universities and over 400 private institutions (including colleges, university colleges and universities) in Malaysia, it is understandable that students may have a hard time deciding between the two. _____
